

INBRIEF



Mizoram House adopts 'Ro Min Rel Sak Ang Che' as State song

The Mizoram Assembly on Thursday unanimously adopted the Mizo patriotic song 'Ro Min Rel Sak Ang Che' as the official State song. Chief Minister Lalduhoma, who moved the resolution, said around 14 States in the country already have their own State songs and there was no objection to having a State song as long as it did not conflict with the National Anthem and the National Song. PTI

40 electric scooters gutted in Bihar showroom fire

A fire broke out at an electric scooter showroom in Bihar's Rohtas district on Thursday morning, gutting around 40 scooters and three e-rickshaws, the police said. The incident took place at Akorhi Gola Bazar in the district. Showroom operator Jitendra Kumar Singh said he was cleaning the premises when the battery of a scooter parked inside exploded. PTI

Correction

The headline, 'ITA calls for targeted invention to safeguard 'troubled' Darjeeling and Dooars tea industry', in an article published in some editions on August 27, 2026, should have read 'ITA calls for targeted intervention...' The error is regretted.

Jharkhand Cong. launches Statewide protest opposing mines and minerals Act

Day-long dharnas held in all 24 districts; Centre attempting to usurp rights of States, says leader; Jharkhand BJP president accuses Congress of seeking to divert attention from 'real' issues

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

The Jharkhand unit of the Congress on Thursday staged protests in all 24 districts against the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026, alleging that it would restrict the State's powers to levy taxes on mineral rights and mineral-bearing land parcels and cause financial losses.

Hitting back, Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) Jharkhand unit chief Aditya Sahu said the Congress's continuous opposition to the Act is merely "a conspiracy to mislead the nation and divert attention from real issues".

Day-long dharnas were organised at Collectorates and memoranda were submitted to President Droupadi Murmu through Deputy Commissioners, seeking her intervention in the matter. In Ranchi, Congress workers led by the party's State president Keshav Mahto Kamlesh took out a protest march



A Congress protest rally in Jharkhand's Koderma on Thursday against the mines and minerals Amendment Act. X/INCJHARKHAND_

from Babu Vatika at Morabadi Ground.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Rajesh Thakur, former Jharkhand Congress chief and AICC observer for West Bengal, said the Central government is making an attempt to usurp the rights of States through the Act and called it a "direct attack" on Jharkhand's economy.

"Jharkhand received mineral-based revenue of approximately ₹1,380 crore in 2024-25 and ₹7,487.91 crore in 2025-26, providing financial

strength to various state development and public welfare schemes. Restricting the right to levy cess on minerals could result in an estimated annual revenue loss of up to ₹14,656 crore for Jharkhand... how will the displaced persons, tribals, and indigenous communities sustain themselves?" said Mr. Thakur.

'Unacceptable move'
The Congress leader said directives from Delhi are unacceptable when the land and minerals belong to Jharkhand and the peo-

ple of Jharkhand bear the brunt of pollution and displacement. He questioned why the Centre is attempting to curtail the States' power to levy a cess when "the Supreme Court has already granted them this right".

Addressing a press conference in Ranchi, Mr. Sahu described Congress as a party devoid of genuine issues.

He also alleged that Congress has turned Jharkhand - where it is a ruling ally of the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha - into "an ATM".

"A massive student agitation is under way, false cases are being filed, and students are being intimidated by the police; Congress wants to divert attention from this issue. It has treated Jharkhand like an ATM and is opposing this Act solely because their wrong income from coal is about to stop; their anger is a reaction to this impending loss," Mr. Sahu said, referring to the recent student protests demanding scrapping of State-level examinations.



Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari during the inauguration of LTM's state-of-the-art IT campus in Kolkata on Thursday. ANI

At IT campus launch, CM invites skilled workers back to W.B.

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Observing that the objective of his government was to create employment opportunities for the State's large pool of educated youth, West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Thursday inaugurated LTM's state-of-the-art IT campus, 'Ananda Niketan', in New Town, Kolkata.

The Chief Minister also urged skilled and educated professionals from the State working elsewhere in India and abroad to return, assuring them of employment opportunities under the "double-engine government".

Mr. Adhikari assured LTM, a Larsen & Toubro group company formerly known as LTMindtree, that the State government

would hand over an additional 10 acres of land for setting up a data centre. The company had written to the government seeking the land around two months ago, he said.

'Premier tech hub'
"West Bengal is moving ahead with immense momentum. With our rich talent pool, upcoming world-class infrastructure and brand new industry-friendly policies, West Bengal is fast cementing its position as the premier tech and innovation hub," Mr. Adhikari said in a social media post.

After the Bharatiya Janata Party government came to power in May this year, the new government has attempted to rebrand West Bengal as an investment destination.

Shah hails water management in Gujarat under Modi; says no drought in State in last 25 years

Press Trust of India
AMRELI

Union Minister Amit Shah on Thursday said Gujarat has undergone a major transformation in water management after Narendra Modi became the State Chief Minister in 2001, and claimed the State did not witness a drought-like situation in the last 25 years.

Mr. Shah was speaking after inaugurating a 21-acre lake developed by a trust run by diamond baron and Padma Shri recipient Savjibhai Dholakia at Dudhala village in Gujarat's Amreli district.

Recalling the severe droughts of 1985, 1986 and 1987, the Union Home Minister alleged that corruption was rampant under the then Congress government, including in the government-run Rafaleswar cattle camp during the



Union Home Minister Amit Shah inaugurating the 'Gujarat Gaurav Sarovar', on World Lake Day, in Amreli on Thursday. PTI

drought period.

"If we create a system to save every single drop of rain and ensure it seeps into the earth, the threat of drought will never loom over our country and State," said Mr. Shah.

'1.5 lakh check dams'
He said the Modi government in the State constructed 1.5 lakh check dams in a single year in

2003 and later expanded water conservation efforts through projects such as the Narmada canal network, SAUNI Yojana and Sujalam Sufalam Yojana.

The foundation stone of the Narmada project was laid by then Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru in 1964, but its gates were opened after Mr. Modi became the Prime Minister, Mr. Shah said.

Bodoland Territorial Council's Deputy Speaker found dead

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Bijit Gwra Narzary, the Deputy Speaker of Assam's Bodoland Territorial Council (BTC), was found dead in Tamulpur district's Kumarkata on Wednesday evening. A Bharatiya Janata Party leader who represented the Darrangajuli constituency of the BTC, he was found dead at his residence. Police said the reason behind his death was being ascertained.

BTC chief mourns death
BTC chief and Bodoland People's Party president Hagrama Mohilary mourned the Deputy Speaker's death.

"I am deeply saddened by the untimely demise of Bijit Gwra Narzary, Honourable Deputy Speaker of the Bodoland Territorial Council. His sudden passing is an irreparable loss to our com-



Bijit Gwra Narzary

munity and public life," Mr. Mohilary said in a condolence message.

Former BTC chief and MP Pramod Boro, who heads the United People's Party Liberal, also offered his condolences on Narzary's demise.

"I pray for the eternal peace of the departed soul and extend my heartfelt condolences to his family, loved ones, and all those mourning this immense loss. May they find strength and courage to overcome this difficult time," he said.

(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help)

BJP's 'true casteist nature' is exposed by its Haldwani ritual defence, says Congress

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Accusing the Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) Uttarakhand unit chief Mahendra Bhatt of defending the alleged purification ritual conducted at a venue in Haldwani after Mallikarjun Kharge addressed a rally there, the Congress on Thursday asked whether the ruling party would act against him for "defending untouchability".

Mr. Bhatt had said the venue had been "polluted" by slogans that were not appropriate for a religious place, dismissing the Opposition's criticism of the ritual.

Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal said the remarks showed that Union Minister J.P. Nadda's expression of regret in the Rajya Sabha over the incident involving



J.P. Nadda's expression of regret in RS a mere eyewash, said Cong. leader K.C. Venugopal

the Congress president was "a mere eyewash".

"It was evident from Day 1 that Union Minister J.P. Nadda's statement of regret in the Rajya Sabha was a mere eyewash. If Mr. Nadda truly meant that the BJP doesn't subscribe to such acts, how is the BJP's own Uttarakhand chief defending the so-called 'shuddhikaran' that their workers did after Kharge ji's event?" Mr. Venugopal wrote in a post on X.

"The BJP's true casteist nature keeps rearing its ugly head, no matter how much cover-up their leaders attempt. If there is even an iota of truth in Mr. Nadda's statement in Parliament, they must sack Mr. Mahendra Bhatt and take strict criminal action against those who insulted Kharge ji," he said.

It's a tragedy: Khera
Congress media and publicity department head Pawan Khera, while sharing a video of Mr. Bhatt's remarks, said, "In the 21st century, Dalits are still subjected to such dehumanising practices. That itself is a tragedy. But if this can happen to the Leader of Opposition in the Rajya Sabha and one of the tallest Dalit leaders in the country, (it) elucidates how far worse the everyday reality must be for ordinary Dalits."

Exam to hire teachers in one phase: Bihar CM

The Hindu Bureau
PATNA

The Bihar government on Thursday agreed to the main demand of protesting students for conducting Teacher Recruitment Examination-4 (TRE-4) in a single phase.

"The government has been serious about the students' demands from the very beginning. Now, a decision has been taken that this year's TRE-4 examination will be conducted in a single phase. Along with this, nine other important decisions have also been made," Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary wrote on X while sharing the information.

Alleged use of children in poll campaign not a ground to set aside victory, T.N. Chief Minister tells Madras HC

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay has contended before the Madras High Court that his rival candidate in the Tiruchi East Assembly constituency, S. Inigo Irudayaraj of the DMK, had failed to demonstrate how the alleged use of children in an election campaign could be raised as a ground for nullifying an election.

"Even assuming the allegations to be correct for the limited purpose of the present application (to reject the election petition)," the election petitioner had failed to plead the necessary material facts to declare an election void under Section 100 of the Representation of the People Act,



The DMK's Irudayaraj had accused Vijay of having "blackmailed" children.

1951, he said.

The submissions were made in an application filed before Justice V. Lakshminarayanan to reject Mr. Irudayaraj's election petition. After hearing senior counsel Srinath Sridevan, assisted by Pranjali Agarwal, appearing for the Chief Minister, the judge directed

the Registry to number the application and list it on August 31.

In his election petition, Mr. Irudayaraj had accused the Chief Minister of having "blackmailed" children during the 2026 Assembly election campaign. "The first respondent (Mr. Vijay) has, through his speeches, emotionally targeted and, to a degree, even blackmailed vulnerable children and impressionable minds to garner the votes of their family members," he said.

However, in his plea to reject the election petition, Mr. Vijay said an election petition could not be filed on the basis of mere assertions that the voters were "emotionally swayed" without there being any material facts to establish that

the appeal made by the returned candidate had resulted in a particular number of votes having been cast in his favour.

The CM also said that though the election petitioner had accused him of having used religion to garner votes, the petitioner had not set out the precise words, communication, or representation. He argued that the allegations regarding excess poll expenditure were vague, and that the expenditure incurred by the TVK functionaries could not be attributed to him.

Separately, Minister for Public Works and Sports Development Aadhav Arjuna of the TVK denied the allegation that he had misrepresented the assets owned by him and his wife, Daisy

Aadhav Arjuna, in his election affidavit, and urged the Madras High Court to reject an election petition filed by his rival candidate, Karthik Mohan of the DMK, challenging his victory from the Villivakkam constituency.

'Correct disclosure'

In the rejection application, also filed before Justice Lakshminarayanan, the Minister said he had made true and correct disclosure in the Form 26 affidavit filed before the Returning Officer, and that even if any information had been misused, that by itself could not become a reason for invalidating an election unless there were materials to prove that such non-disclosure had materially affected the result of the polls.

BJD opposes biometric attendance proposal for college students

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

The Biju Janata Dal (BJD) on Thursday criticised the Mohan Majhi-led Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government's move to introduce biometric attendance system for students, alleging it was an attempt to intimidate students.

"The State government, in an attempt to hide its own inefficiency, is talking about biometric attendance for students... The government is trying to intimidate students in the name of discipline. Such an approach of the government towards Gen Z is not appropriate," said BJD spokesperson Lenin Mohanty.

"Biometric attendance has still not been introduced for teachers and staff in colleges across the State. In this context, proposing to introduce a biometric attendance system for students is a reflection of the Tughlaqi policy of the government," he said, also claiming that BJP leaders are interfering in the management of colleges.

Mr. Mohanty pointed out that the government announced free education from kindergarten (KG) to postgraduate (PG) level in the State. "However, no clear instructions in this regard have been issued, due to which fees are still being collected from students," he said.

Centre blames middlemen as onion prices hit ₹62 per kg

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Union government on Thursday blamed “black marketing, hoarding and profiteering” for the increasing price of onions across the country and said the essential vegetable will be made available for retail sale at a discounted price of ₹35 per kilogram through designated mobile vans in cities such as Delhi. On Thursday, the price for a kilogram of onion in the Delhi market was ₹62.

The Consumer Affairs Ministry said the National Agricultural Cooperative Marketing Federation of India Limited (Nafed), and the National Cooperative Consumers’ Federation of India Limited (NCCF) will sell the onions through its retail stores and the Kendriya Bhandars under the price stabilisation measures.

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said middlemen are the reason for the increase in onion prices and the farmers should get a reasonable income while the consumers should get the product at a reasonable rate.

India, China discuss ways to clarify LAC perceptions and settle concerns

Both sides agree that ‘any situation on the ground would be addressed promptly through existing diplomatic and military channels’; a consensus statement likely after talks between NSA Ajit Doval and China’s Foreign Minister Wang Yi in Beijing

Ananth Krishnan
BEIJING

India and China discussed ways to improve their understanding of each other’s perception of the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in the 25th Round of Special Representatives talks on the boundary question held in Beijing on Tuesday.

Indian and Chinese officials see differing perceptions of the LAC in some areas as a key factor behind tensions in both Western and Eastern Sectors.

The eight-point outcome document released on Wednesday, a day after the talks between National Security Adviser Ajit Doval and China’s Foreign Minister Wang Yi in Beijing, acknowledged those concerns. It said the two sides “discussed ways to improve understanding of LAC in appropriate areas, for better border management”.

The joint consensus statement noted both sides agreed that “any situation on the ground would be addressed promptly



India has long pushed for clarifying the LAC to reduce likelihood of incidents between patrols in areas where claims overlap. FILE PHOTO

through existing diplomatic and military channels, including the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination (WMCC), local commander-level meetings and other agreed mechanisms, to resolve outstanding issues and avoid misunderstanding along the LAC.”

Another key outcome said an Expert Group on Boundary Delimitation would “advance discussions on an Early and Substantial Harvest of boundary delimitation”. That process, which would start

with both sides agreeing to the terms of reference, is expected to focus on sectors where there are no pronounced differences in alignment.

India has long pitched for clarifying the LAC to reduce the likelihood of incidents between patrols in areas where claims overlap. The 1996 agreement on confidence-building measures noted the need for the two sides “arriving at a common understanding of the alignment of the LAC” and said both “agree to speed up the process of clarification of the LAC”.

Both sides then agreed to exchange maps indicating their respective perceptions of the entire alignment of the LAC. To that end, maps were exchanged in the Middle Sector a few years later, but the process ran aground when it came to the Western Sector in light of sharp divergences, and was subsequently abandoned in Western and Eastern sectors.

During his first visit to China as Prime Minister in 2015, Narendra Modi made a public pitch to resume the LAC clarification process. That did not happen, with Chinese officials saying a clarification process on LAC alignment would further complicate attempts to resolve the boundary dispute.

However, the tensions in eastern Ladakh starting in April 2020, marking the most serious disruption to peace along the LAC since 1962, sharply underlined the need to address differences over alignment, especially in the Western Sector. In the Eastern Sector in Arunachal Pradesh as well, differing percep-

tions of LAC alignment were cited for tensions earlier this month.

Both sides have informally addressed the issue to some extent at the ground level at the many rounds of talks between the Senior Highest Military Commanders. Following disengagement from friction points in Ladakh, the two sides worked out modalities to help keep the peace, such as no-patrolling zones and coordinated patrolling in contested areas. Neither side has shared details on the modalities being followed.

The outcome document eschewed any reference to clarification, and, given the contested history of the term, a resumption of the process envisaged in 1996 remains unlikely. However, the two Special Representatives did give a political endorsement of the need “to improve understanding of the LAC in appropriate areas”, opening the door for both sides to, at the very least, initiate a process of better understanding the other’s perceptions.

Conflicting claims made on Pak.-China ties, says Congress

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

Seeking a comprehensive official review of Operation Sindoor, Congress leader Jairam Ramesh on Thursday questioned what he described as conflicting statements by senior military officials on the extent of cooperation between Pakistan and China during the operation.

India had launched the operation against terror camps in Pakistan in May 2025 in response to the Pahalgam attack.

In a post on X, Mr. Ramesh shared two video clips and contrasted the remarks made by Deputy Chief of Army Staff Lt. Gen. Rahul Singh on July 4, 2025, and former Chief of Defence Staff Gen. Anil Chauhan on August 25, 2026.

‘Nation is confused’

Mr. Ramesh said Lt. Gen. Singh had revealed the very disturbingly deep nature of the Pakistan-China *jugalbandi* [close ties] during Operation Sindoor.

However, he said Gen. Chauhan’s more recent remarks on the same issue

Jairam Ramesh seeks official review of Operation Sindoor; highlights differing accounts by officials

were simply opposite to what the Army officer had stated. “The nation is confused,” Mr. Ramesh said.

He questioned whether there was a deeper plan to change the narrative surrounding Operation Sindoor.

“What is going on here? Is there some deeper plan to change the narrative? Is this part of the calibrated capitulation to China on the part of the Modi govt. that has been in clear evidence for a long while since the PM’s infamous clean chit to China on June 2020 and the record trade deficits with China... that his Government has presided over?” he said on X. “The nation needs to know,” he said.

Mr. Ramesh has been calling for a comprehensive official review of Operation Sindoor, arguing that differing accounts by senior officials warrant a structured examination.

Cong. accuses Centre of facilitating a ‘sugar scam’ ahead of festival season

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Thursday accused the Narendra Modi government of facilitating a ₹36,000-crore “sugar scam”, alleging that its failure to act on a shortage allowed hoarders and black-marketeers to profit from a sharp rise in sugar prices ahead of the festive season.

Addressing a press conference, Congress general secretary Randeep Surjewala said the government knew in April that there would be a shortage but “sat quietly” and did not act.

Explaining the issue, he said that the opening stock of sugar for 2025-26 was 50 lakh tonnes, which was 30 lakh tonnes lower than the previous year. On April 30 this year, the Indian Sugar & Bio-energy Manufacturers’ Association had stated that sugar production was 275 lakh tonnes.

Further, he said around 120 lakh tonnes of sugar was expected to be consumed between August and November. And already, the price of retail sugar



Congress general secretary Randeep Surjewala addressing the media in New Delhi on Thursday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

has gone from ₹45 to ₹75 per kg. At an additional ₹30 a kg, he said, consumers would collectively pay ₹36,000 crore more, benefiting hoarders and black-marketeers.

“When people celebrate Dussehra and Deepavali, they will face the brunt of the price rise of sugar this year and shell out more from their pockets. The 120 lakh tonnes of sugar will amount to ₹36,000 crore, which will directly benefit hoarders and black-marketeers. What could be a bigger example of collusion with those in power,” Mr. Surjewala asked.

“Due to less production and swindling of stocks, su-

gar has become expensive during the festive season,” the Congress leader said, alleging that “this is the Modi government’s new masterstroke to openly rob the public”.

Mr. Surjewala claimed that the government had used 32% of sugar cane stocks for producing E20 fuel between November 2025 and July 2026, leaving less sugar available in the market for consumers.

He demanded that the government restore the scheme of providing 500 grams of sugar to every member of a family at subsidised rates through the Public Distribution System.

NCW forms panel to probe ‘trafficking’ of women in Mewat

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Amid concerns over the alleged trafficking and exploitation of women in the name of marriage, the National Commission for Women (NCW) has constituted a five-member fact-finding team to examine the practice of ‘*Paro*’ or ‘*Molki*’ marriages in Mewat region, particularly in the Nuh district of Haryana.

‘*Paro*’ or ‘*Molki*’ refers to a practice in which women, often from economically vulnerable communities in other States, are brought through intermediaries and married to men in the region, allegedly involving monetary transactions with brokers or the woman’s family.

The Commission has taken cognisance of reports alleging that women are brought to the region and married off in exchange for money. In some reported cases, women are allegedly resold and subjected to repeated abuse and exploitation.

“...The concerns surrounding ‘*Paro*’ or ‘*Molki*’

Panel will examine practice of poor women being ‘sold’ into marriages and subsequent abuse

marriages are serious and require a fact-based examination. The NCW will ensure that the voices, rights and dignity of women affected by this practice are not overlooked. If trafficking, exploitation or systemic failures are found, the Commission will recommend firm and effective measures to prevent their recurrence,” said NCW chairperson Vijaya Rahatkar.

The panel will undertake an on-the-spot inquiry in Nuh/Mewat and other locations, as considered necessary, and interact with survivors, local residents, police and civil administration officials and other stakeholders.

It has been asked to submit its report to the Commission within 10 working days of its constitution, along with recommendations for preventing the recurrence of such practices.

Kharge urges PM to share delimitation plan, freeze Lok Sabha strength at 543

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Thursday called for the existing strength of the Lok Sabha to be frozen at 543 seats for the next 25 years and sought implementation of one-third reservation for women from the 2029 Lok Sabha election.

In a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Mr. Kharge urged him to share the government’s proposals on delimitation with all political parties and the State governments. “This is an issue that has enormous significance for the country,” he said, adding: Please do not again try and bulldoze [the Bill through Parliament] as you attempted on April 16 and 17, 2026.”

Mr. Kharge sought an all-party meeting to discuss the delimitation proposals and adequate time for political parties and State governments to study them before any legislation is brought before Parliament in a special session.

Referring to his July 16



Mallikarjun Kharge

letter to Mr. Modi in which he had made a similar appeal, Mr. Kharge said: “I am writing now to reiterate this request since the Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs has publicly stated in a television interview last night that such a special session of Parliament could well be convened.”

Three demands

Mr. Kharge said the Congress was clear on three points – maintaining the existing strength of the Lok Sabha at 543 for the next 25 years, retaining the existing State-wise allocation of seats for the same period, and introducing one-third reservation for women from the 2029 election.

“Before you go ahead as indicated by the Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs, I wish to reiterate my earlier request to you to – convene an all-party meeting to discuss whatever delimitation proposals you have in mind; give all political parties and State governments adequate time to study such proposals,” he said.

On August 19, the Congress Working Committee (CWC), the party’s highest decision-making body, called for the Lok Sabha’s strength to be frozen at 543 seats, as well as the existing State-wise allocation, for 25 years, while seeking implementation of one-third reservation for women from 2029.

The Congress’s latest position is also in line with a unanimous resolution adopted by the Tamil Nadu Assembly on delimitation.

During the Budget Session on April 17, a Constitution amendment Bill involving delimitation for implementing women’s reservation was defeated in the Lok Sabha.

BJP cites website to target Rahul Gandhi

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party on Thursday cited a website that claims to fact-check statements made by Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi during his “*Chhatron Ki Goonj*” campaign, accusing him of misleading the youth.

BJP MP and the party’s national media head, Anil Baluni, said, “Let Mr. Gandhi keep lying, it doesn’t matter...now, every lie will be met with a response backed by hard facts! The ‘*Jhooth Ki Goonj*’ website is peeling back the

layers of Mr. Gandhi’s false claims, one by one.”

BJP spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi said on X, “No matter how much Rahul Gandhi, the flag-bearer of lies fuelled by frustration and envy towards Prime Minister Shri @narendramodi ji, continues to spread falsehoods, every lie is now being exposed in the mirror of facts.”

BJP spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari alleged that the youth were “so irritated and angry at the series of falsehoods” spread by Mr. Gandhi that they launched the website to counter them.

Ahead of Sept. 1 rally, CPI hits out at Centre over economy, education

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Ahead of its ‘Badlaav Zaroori Hai’ (Change is Necessary) rally at Delhi’s Ramlila Maidan on September 1, the Communist Party of India on Thursday launched a broadside at the Narendra Modi-led government, accusing it of failing to address economic distress, weakening democratic institutions, undermining federalism, and responding to public dissent with repression rather than engagement.

Addressing a press conference at the party’s head-



D. Raja

quarters in Ajoy Bhawan in New Delhi, CPI general secretary D. Raja said the country was facing multiple crises, including unemployment, rising prices, declining purchasing power, growing inequality, and

pressure on public education and healthcare systems. He said farmers continued to demand a legal guarantee for minimum support price (MSP), while workers faced increasing insecurity and students were being subjected to police action for raising legitimate concerns.

‘Troubling trend’

Referring to recent protests by students and youth across the country, Mr. Raja said the government had failed to address concerns over jobs, education and examination-related controversies. He pointed to

police action against student protesters in Delhi, Jharkhand and Bihar as a troubling trend.

“The incidents of violence against students are particularly serious because they demonstrate how the ordinary exercise of democratic rights can be treated as a law-and-order threat by the BJP,” Mr. Raja said.

“Students protesting peacefully should not have to fear police action, detention or physical injury,” he added, while also criticising BJP leaders for allegedly branding protesters as “*dimagi* Naxals”.

13 held for double murder in Bengal

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

The West Bengal Police have arrested 13 people in connection with the murders of Congress leader Anisur Rahman and his son Abu Sufiyan at Nakasipara in Nadia district on August 15, officials said on Thursday.

“A total of 13 people, including suspects from Karnataka and Odisha, have been arrested in the Nakasipara double murder and vehicles used in the crime have been seized,” a police official said.

The Congress leader and his son were killed by

miscreants on a motorcycle who fired upon their vehicle at the Nakasipara railway gate. After several rounds were fired at the vehicle, the two were dragged out and hacked to death.

Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari had said Trinamool Congress activists were behind the murder.

Fatima Bibi – a Trinamool member and local panchayat head – was earlier arrested along with two associates in connection with the murders. Her husband, Jubbar Sheikh, who is currently in prison over a separate case, allegedly plotted the murders.

West Bengal launches efforts to find 32 pilgrims who travelled for Kailash-Mansarovar Yatra; former Union Minister Mukul Roy's daughter-in-law is part of the group; Isha Foundation in T.N. says pilgrim group of 80 from various countries missing; measures to bring back people being worked on

A IN-Y

HEALTH

The changing face of skin lightening practices in India

The language around skin lightening has changed, but the desire for it has remained strong in India; a lot of the advertisement and marketing has now moved online; the country needs strong legislation, campaigns to educate patients, pharmacists and healthcare professionals, and a conversation that shifts the focus to skin health, not colour

Monisha Madhumita

The language of fairness may be changing, but the desire for lighter skin has not necessarily disappeared in our country. As skin-lightening practices move into skincare, dermatological procedures and digital spaces, the health consequences are becoming increasingly harder to recognise and regulate.

Skin lightening in India is changing. The fairness creams that once dominated advertisements are less visible today. The language around them has also shifted. Words such as ‘brightening’, ‘glow’, ‘de-tan’ and ‘even tone’ are now common across skincare products and digital platforms.

For dermatologists, this change is increasingly visible in clinical practice.

Patients may not come to the clinic saying that they have been trying to become fairer. They often present because something has already gone wrong. There may be acne, redness, thinning of the skin, increased facial hair, pigmentation or infections. Oral agents used with the expectation of achieving lighter skin are also being sought.

“We see patients because of the side-effects of what they have tried, and then work backwards,” says Rashmi Sarkar, head and director - professor, department of dermatology Vardhman Mahavir Medical College and Safdarjung hospital, New Delhi.

The profile is changing too. What was once viewed largely as a concern among women is now also seen among men, teenagers and transgender persons. This makes skin lightening an important skin-health issue, rather than simply a cosmetic concern.

Not all treatment that reduces pigmentation is skin lightening.

Melasma and post-inflammatory hyperpigmentation are common pigmentary disorders. They can be persistent and distressing, particularly in darker skin tones. These conditions may require treatment. The important distinction, Dr. Sarkar says, is between treating a pigmentary disorder and attempting to lighten a person’s normal, constitutive skin colour. This distinction is becoming less clear to consumers.

A product described as ‘brightening’ may be intended to reduce pigmentation, improve dullness or make the skin appear more even. The term itself does not explain what is being changed.

For clinicians, the focus should remain on skin health. Brighter-looking skin can follow better photoprotection, appropriate skincare, control of inflammation and improvements in general health and lifestyle. None of these requires changing a person’s natural skin colour.

Digital shift

The larger change is taking place online.

Skin-lightening messages are no longer limited to television advertisements or product packaging. They are increasingly delivered through influencers, e-commerce platforms, before-and-after photographs and social media.



Need for regulation: Skin-lightening messages are no longer limited to television advertisements or product packaging. They are increasingly delivered through influencers, e-commerce platforms, before-and-after photographs and social media. GETTY IMAGES

Algorithms can amplify these messages. A person who watches one video on pigmentation may subsequently be shown repeated content around brightening products, supplements, peels or procedures. Filters and image manipulation add another layer. Photographs can be altered to make skin appear lighter, smoother or more uniform. Artificial intelligence can make these alterations increasingly difficult to recognise.

Dr. Sarkar believes public education, must therefore, also address digital literacy. People need to learn to recognise filtered or manipulated images and to question the aesthetic standards repeatedly presented to them online.

The impact is particularly relevant for younger users. Repeated exposure can gradually alter what is perceived as normal skin and what is considered a problem requiring correction.

Excessive treatment

The growth of aesthetic skincare has also widened the number of places where people seek treatment.

Patients may move between dermatology clinics, aesthetic centres, salons, spas, social media and online marketplaces. The distinction between medical treatment and cosmetic marketing can become unclear.

Dr. Sarkar stresses that pigmentary disorders should be assessed by qualified dermatologists. Procedures also need to be selected carefully and patients should not be overtreated. This is particularly relevant in darker skin tones, where inflammation caused by aggressive treatment can itself lead to further pigmentation. The treatment can then become part of the problem.

There is also a role for clinicians in managing expectations. Not every variation in skin colour requires treatment. Unregulated over-the-counter

skin-lightening products should be avoided and unrealistic expectations need to be addressed early.

The health consequences can be significant. The International League of Dermatological Societies (ILDS) has warned that the misuse of potent topical corticosteroids in skin-bleaching products can contribute to treatment-resistant fungal infections, irreversible skin damage and systemic side-effects. The organisation has called for stronger regulation, clearer guidance and better public education.

Beyond the clinic

The response to skin lightening therefore also needs to change.

Traditional awareness campaigns remain important, but they may no longer be sufficient when much of the contemporary conversation is taking place online. This is a particular focus of the ILDS Strategic Working Group on Skin Bleaching. The group brings together international dermatology expertise to address harmful skin-lightening practices while also recognising the legitimate need for safe, evidence-based treatment of pigmentary disorders.

The message, says Dr. Sarkar, who is part of the working group, needs to reach people where these practices are now being discussed and promoted. “We need to leverage social media and amplify the message,” she says. This includes closer collaboration between the ILDS and national dermatology societies, as well as engagement with pharmacists, educators and credible public voices.

India has previously seen organised campaigns around inappropriate topical steroid use. These efforts included education of both patients and pharmacists. A similar approach is now needed for contemporary skin-lightening practices.

The ILDS initiative also has a wider

aim: to move the conversation away from skin colour as an aesthetic hierarchy and towards skin health. The message is simple, but important. Healthy skin exists in every shade.

For those experimenting with skincare routines, particularly skin lightening, it means understanding the difference between a pigmentary disorder and normal skin colour. It means recognising that medicines used without appropriate supervision can damage the skin. It means knowing that repeated procedures are not always better treatment. Increasingly, it also means understanding that the images seen online may have been filtered, lightened or otherwise altered.

Regulation will need to evolve alongside this change. Looking only for products explicitly labelled as ‘fairness’ products will miss part of the contemporary market. Claims, ingredients, digital advertising, influencer marketing and access to potent medicines all require attention. But regulation alone cannot address the deeper issue.

Greater awareness has made overt fairness advertising less acceptable. Yet, as Dr. Sarkar points out, social perceptions around skin colour continue to persist. The challenge is therefore no longer only the fairness cream. The people seeking these interventions are also changing. The response now needs to change with them.

For dermatologists, professional societies and public-health organisations, the opportunity lies in moving beyond treating complications after they occur. The focus must be on prevention, evidence-based care, digital education and a clearer understanding of what healthy skin actually means.

(Dr. Monisha Madhumita is a consultant dermatologist at Saveetha Medical College, Chennai. mail.monisha.m@gmail.com)

THE GIST

As skin-lightening practices move into skincare, dermatological procedures and digital spaces, the health consequences are becoming increasingly harder to recognise and regulate

For clinicians, the focus should remain on skin health. Brighter-looking skin can follow better photoprotection, appropriate skincare, control of inflammation and improvements in general health and lifestyle. None of these requires changing a person’s natural skin colour

There is also a role for clinicians in managing expectations. Not every variation in skin colour requires treatment. Unregulated over-the-counter skin-lightening products should be avoided and unrealistic expectations need to be addressed early

Salmonella infections: why India needs to look beyond typhoid and diarrhoea

Athira Elssa Johnson

Salmonella is often linked to food poisoning, diarrhoea and typhoid. But the infection can range from mild gastroenteritis that gets better on its own to a serious bloodstream infection, and therefore, say experts, deserves more attention than it is currently being given.

Salmonella is a group of bacteria that can cause different infections. Typhoid and paratyphoid or enteric fever, are caused by Salmonella Typhi and Salmonella Paratyphi. The problem, however, is broader than typhoid. Non-typhoidal Salmonella infections, which often cause gastroenteritis, may go undiagnosed because many people recover without testing. At the same time, antibiotic resistance is making serious infections harder to treat.

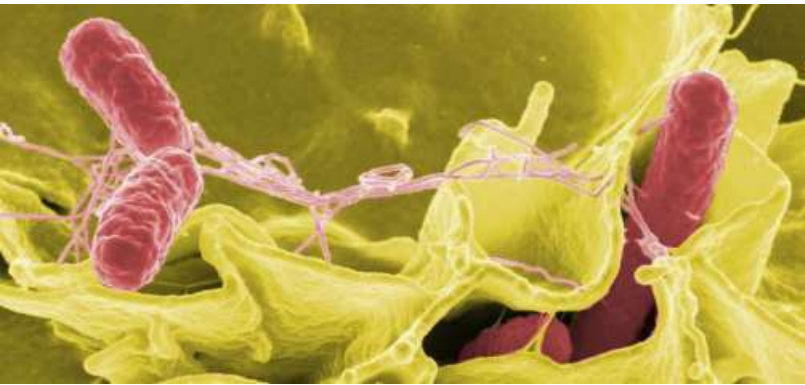
Why infections turn serious

Non-typhoidal Salmonella commonly causes gastroenteritis, with diarrhoea, stomach cramps, fever and sometimes vomiting. It is

often linked to poultry, eggs and other animal-based foods. Most healthy people recover with supportive care, but the infection can become serious and spread to the bloodstream. “Salmonella should not be seen as only a cause of diarrhoea,” said Sweatha Kumar, associate consultant, infectious diseases, Rela Hospital, Chennai. “In some patients, especially young children, older adults and those living with other illnesses or weakened immunity, it can become invasive and life-threatening.”

Suresh Kumar D., senior specialist in infectious diseases, Apollo Speciality Hospitals, Vanagaram, Chennai, said the actual burden of non-typhoidal Salmonella is difficult to estimate as many mild infections are never diagnosed.

Both typhoid and non-typhoidal Samonella infections spread through the faecal-oral route, but their sources are different. For typhoid, humans are the reservoir. Non-typhoidal Salmonella has a wider ecology, involving animals, food and the environment. Poultry,



Preventing infections: Typhoid conjugate vaccines, safer water and sanitation, food safety and antimicrobial stewardship all have a role in reducing infections. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

eggs, meat and other animal-derived foods can be sources. Transmission can also occur when raw meat contaminates ready-to-eat food during preparation.

“Contamination can occur at multiple points, from farms, slaughterhouses and food processing to transportation, storage, restaurants and finally the household kitchen,” Dr. Sweatha said. “That is why Salmonella is very much a One Health problem

involving humans, animals, food and the environment.”

Food handlers can play an important role in transmission, as those carrying the infection can contaminate food and potentially expose many people to the bacteria. But food safety cannot depend only on individual food handlers. The wider system needs better training, sanitation, refrigeration, monitoring and enforcement. While the Food Safety and Standards Authority of

India has surveillance and testing systems, gaps remain, particularly in the large informal food sector.

At the household level, it is important follow: washing hands, using safe water, cooking poultry and eggs thoroughly, refrigerating perishable foods appropriately and keeping raw meat separate from ready-to-eat food.

Challenges and way forward

The major concern is the growing antimicrobial resistance in Salmonella. India has seen a major shift in the resistance pattern of S. Typhi. A recent study in *PLOS Neglected Tropical Diseases* said, culture-confirmed isolates from 1977 to 2024 found that fluoroquinolone resistance rose sharply, reaching 85% in 2015-19, and remains high despite a subsequent decline.

“The emergence and spread of extensively drug-resistant typhoid shows what can happen when resistance accumulates across multiple antibiotic classes,” Dr. Sweatha said, “It can leave clinicians with very limited treatment options.”

Experts say the answer is not to simply use stronger antibiotics. Blood culture is the main test for suspected typhoid and should ideally be done before antibiotics are started. The Widal test has limitations and should not be used alone to diagnose typhoid. For uncomplicated non-typhoidal Salmonella gastroenteritis, treatment mainly involves adequate fluids and electrolyte replacement. Antibiotics are usually reserved for severe or invasive infections and people at higher risk of complications.

Prevention remains as important as treatment. The World Health Organization recommends typhoid conjugate vaccines for children from six months of age; however, this not yet part of India’s universal immunisation programme.

The challenge is to treat the infections that genuinely require antibiotics while preventing the infections that can be prevented in the first place.

(athira.elssa@thehindu.co.in)



Apoorvanand
Professor in the Hindi department of the University of Delhi



Ganesh Devy
Former professor of English and the man behind the People's Linguistic Survey of India project

PARLEY

The Supreme Court has been discussing linguistics this month while hearing challenges to the CBSE's three-language formula, which mandates that two of the three languages must be native Indian languages, a category that does not include English. The top court had wondered whether it was correct to treat English as a "non-indigenous" language, given its long history in the country, and its role as a link language in governance and higher education. So should English be considered a foreign language in India? Apoorvanand and Ganesh Devy discuss the question in a conversation moderated by **Priscilla Jebaraj**.

Is English a foreign language in India?

Apoorvanand: No. It came from outside the geography that we define as India now. But it has been Indianised. We cannot now say that English is foreign to the soil because it's being used in different forms and for different purposes by people across India.

Ganesh Devy: Hindi and English are born of the same Indo-European language family. One part of that family came to us 3,500 years ago; that was Sanskrit and one of the descendants of Sanskrit is Hindi. Another part came through Europe 400 years ago, in the 17th century. So, they both belong to the same root language, and both of them have come to us at different times.

In fact, the only major indigenous language in India is Tamil as it does not come from outside. But for that reason, we cannot impose Tamil on all students. Similarly, we cannot impose English or Hindi. So in India, the language question cannot simply be seen in terms of which is foreign, which is indigenous.

The history of English in India includes both imperialism and the freedom movement, Macaulay and Gandhi. How has this complicated the issue?

GD: Macaulay's minute is relatively recent, dated 1835; the East India Company had started using English in India almost 230 years before that. The interaction between English and other languages started in the 17th century and intensified during the 18th century. In the 19th century, the English governors in Calcutta, Bombay, and Madras insisted on teaching children in native languages, that is, the regional languages. Elphinstone very clearly gave written instructions to teach children in Gujarati and Marathi in the Bombay presidency. But by 1835, the East India Company was thinking of how to bring in legislation to replace Persian, which had been kind of a national language connecting India for several centuries, and that is when Macaulay came in.

AP: English came as a language of traders and



A semi-open class in a school in New Delhi on January 24. R.V. MOORTHY

missionaries and gradually became the language of the administration and the state, but then it also became the language of education. We see an elite being formed through English and also the formation of nationalism or nationalist ideas through English. So that's a very complex journey. We cannot treat English as a simple imposition on Indians. Indians adopted it, domesticated it, and then used it against those who had colonised India. Then, it became a language of liberation for many communities who did not have access to education or knowledge for generations.

English has become the language of aspiration and status. How does that impact social and political dynamics?

GD: The creation of an English-speaking elite has to be seen in the historical context of an earlier experience, where Sanskrit had formed an elite which brought in the *varna* system. The English language created an elite in India who tried to change that system and make India a modern society. Moreover, in India, in order to get a good job one often needs to migrate outside one's State. And as soon as migration is involved, the need for English is enhanced.

AP: English is connected with social mobility as well as geographical mobility. No other language gives you this advantage.

According to the 2011 Census, 10% of the Indian population speak English, and the numbers are only increasing. Has this resulted in the suppression of other Indian languages or has it spread multilingualism?

AP: It would be very simplistic to make a direct cause and effect relationship, because multi-linguality is a feature of India and there are different reasons for which people use different languages at different levels. In my Delhi classroom, the students are largely from the so-called Hindi belt. But for most of them, their home or street language is actually Bhojpuri or Braj or Avadhi or Maithili. So there are many languages which live side-by-side,



We cannot treat English as a simple imposition on Indians. Indians adopted it, domesticated it, and then used it against those who had colonised India. It became a language of liberation for many communities

APOORVANAND

performing different functions.

Being a teacher of Hindi, I regret that Hindi is in fact erasing many languages, which had a very rich tradition and which are living languages such as Maithali or Braj or Avadhi or Dondari or even Adivasi languages, because the state is not investing in them. They have now become oral languages, pushed to the margins, while all attention goes to Hindi. It's Hindi imperialism in Hindi areas; Hindi is a coloniser.

What is the impact of the rise of English as well as Hindi on other languages?

GD: First, let me say that the Census of India is not at all a clear mirror as far as language is concerned. For example, if a language is spoken by less than 10,000 persons, the Census says it is not a language. Then, if you look at how many individuals are studying in universities in India, the total figure at any given time in the last 10 years would be about four crore. Each one of them know English as a second language because English is the language of higher education, and yet the Census does not reflect those figures.

Hindi has been gulping other languages. In the Census itself, some 56 other languages are included as subsets of Hindi. There is a language called Pawri which is spoken by the Pawra Adivasi community, on the border of Maharashtra and Madhya Pradesh, who do not understand Hindi at all. Yet that is shown as a subset of Hindi. It is the same with Tamil, Kannada and Marathi. All smaller languages are being shown as subsets of larger languages and that comes from the state's desire to have some kind of linguistic unity.

India is made of many languages and that is the fundamental truth. Just last week, in Maharashtra, rickshaw drivers and taxi drivers were on strike because there is a compulsion that they have to pass an examination in Marathi, based on grammar. Why would a taxi driver need Marathi grammar? He has functional Marathi. Indians speak a lot of functional languages. They speak English, not as the British do, but as a functional language. They speak Hindi all over India as a functional language. And I think we should never forsake the beauty of having multiple functional languages in our pocket, in our hearts, and in our brains.

But there is also a vested interest in English in India from English language publishers and English medium schools. They bat for the continuance of English partly out of commercial

interest. I don't agree with that.

AP: On the CBSE and their stress on a three-language formula, and the insistence of policymakers that they want children to learn the mother tongue – all this is farcical because people know that all these policymakers are sending their own children to English medium schools and that English is social capital, cultural capital, and capital in real terms.

There's also a significant amount of Indian literature written in English today, including works in translation. And of course, films and the Internet freely mix languages. How does that change the debate?

GD: In the 6th, 7th, and 8th centuries, many Indians produced books in Sanskrit. Then, in the 15th and 16th centuries, India was producing more books in Persian. Today, India is producing more books in English than they produce in England. But our desi languages have still survived.

So the production of books, movies, and songs in a certain language is not necessarily an indication of a profound fundamental cultural shift. There are just two small questions to be asked to anybody who is writing English fiction or non-fiction. The first is, when that person goes into any spiritual space, is their prayer also in English? The second question is, is the audience only Indian or is it a global audience? The answers to these two questions will reveal the exact significance of the shift.

By the way, the English came here and had an impact on many things. But Indian music remains Indian music. We have internalised but not replaced. So, our cultural reception of English culture has been calibrated, granular, and is not wholesale as in Australia, U.S. or in Canada where native cultures were wiped out.

AP: I would disagree with that. For example, in my daughter's generation or the generation after, their first love in music is through English and not "Indian music". I don't see any problem in that and I don't see them as culturally uprooted. Would we say that this young generation or those bands which sing only in English are not culturally Indian? It's a very complex concept and the whole anxiety about maintaining nativity and creating a difference between what is indigenous and what is foreign is also problematic. Therefore, I would like to argue that English has made India its home. Those who want to declare that it's a foreign language, in fact, want to hide the fact that Hindi colonises other languages and so do Tamil and other languages, when you create these as meta languages and others as sub languages.



To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
www.thehindu.com

NOTEBOOK

Rajinikanth, a secret Chennai park, and a Gandhi impersonator

Stories don't always begin with pitches; sometimes, they can emerge from unexpected gates and casual strolls

Srinivasa Ramanujam

The best stories in journalism are not necessarily the ones that begin with a strong pitch, or take hours of research and painstaking reporting; sometimes, they are the ones that a reporter simply discovers along the way.

Recently, I challenged myself to find the place where actor Rajinikanth had shot his first film, *Apoorva Raagangal*, in 1975. Tamil cinema fans will remember the iconic shot of the newcomer pushing open a gate and striding into a house – almost as if announcing his arrival in filmdom.

I was determined to find this gate and the house.

Armed with a few clues from old-timers, I managed to find it at a dead-end street in a quiet Adyar neighbourhood. The gate had changed, but the house was spectacularly intact, almost exactly as it had appeared in the old Tamil film starring Rajinikanth and Kamal Haasan. We spoke to the owners and shot a video in which I mimicked the way Rajinikanth strode in, standing at the exact same place.

Story done, I was ready to head out when I chanced upon a small gate on the opposite side. It looked like the entrance to a park, but seemed deserted. Curious, I walked in, only to discover a walk-through park along the Adyar river. It was one of the most beautiful sights I had seen in Chennai, a city I have lived in for over four decades.

In some strange way, the wooded trail and quiet pathway felt like they belonged to me. Ever since this discovery, I've dragged along all my favourite people to experience it and take a stroll. I wrote about it too, while refusing to divulge the exact location lest it become too crowded.

Another time, a visit to a popular landmark led me to a story I wasn't looking for.

On a boring weekend afternoon, after a Sunday nap, my daughter pestered me to take her out. We decided to head to the Marina Beach for some fresh air and to try our hand at balloon shooting. As we strolled towards the sea, something odd caught my attention: a man dressed as Mahatma Gandhi, his body covered in silver paint, standing completely still. He would occasionally wave at children, but otherwise he looked like a statue. He had a box in front of him and even a QR code stuck to his trousers for those who preferred digital payments.

I asked him for his number and he mumbled something in Telugu. Days and many conversations later, with the help of a translator, I wrote about this man from Khammam in Telangana who dresses as Gandhi.

He said with regret that people were forgetting Gandhi and this was his way of reminding them about the father of the nation. This was also one way in which he was saving up for his daughter's wedding.

The same happened in Varanasi, where a casual stroll along Assi Ghat led me to a unique training ground for *gusthi* wrestlers. Before long, another story fell into place: I found that many young boys and girls go to the ground for strength training and learn *gusthi* in order to participate in local tournaments. Varanasi may be known for its spirituality, but physical fitness too is deeply woven into its culture.

One of the cardinal rules of life, and perhaps even more so in journalism, is to be curious, not judgmental. Curiosity is often the starting point for stories that reporters never set out to find.

As a journalist, it's not always about finding a story; sometimes, it's about allowing the story to find you.

srinivasa.r@thehindu.co.in

PICTURE OF THE WEEK

Tasting childhood



A sweet treat: Children eating chewy candy, a popular sweet of the city, at the landmark Marina beach in Chennai, which has been celebrating Madras Week, on August 27. R. RAGU

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO AUGUST 28, 1976

Thanjavur teak to be auctioned

Tiruchi, August 27: For the first time teak grown on canal banks in Thanjavur will be put on auction by the Forest Department, Mr. K.A. Bhoja Shetty, Chief Conservator of Forests and Mr. Venkatakrishnan, Conservator of Forests, Tiruchi circle, said here to-day.

The Tamil Nadu Forest Department has proved that teak could be profitably grown on canal banks, they added and paid tributes to Mr. V.S. Krishnaswamy, erstwhile Chief Conservator of Forests, at whose initiative the Department took up teak cultivation on the canal banks of the Cauvery delta in Thanjavur district in 1955-56.

To-day teak has been raised over the entire network of the canal system in Thanjavur district covering an area of 8,000 hectares.

The first auction of the Thanjavur teak will be conducted on September 3 at Saliamangalam before the Conservator of Forests. All along teak came from the western ghats and hereafter at periodical intervals of three or six months, Thanjavur teak would be auctioned.

At the first auction over 2,500 poles would be available for bidding, Mr. Bhoja Shetty said.

Mr. Shetty added that similar teak plantations had been raised throughout the Cauvery baks and Tambarabarani bank belts.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO AUGUST 28, 1926

Indian methods of teaching

A correspondent writes:– Dr. B.B. Dey, Professor of Chemistry, Presidency College, Madras, delivered the inaugural address of the Science Branch, Teachers' College Teachers' Association, Saidapet, on Wednesday, 25th at 5 p.m.

The lecturer pointed out that teaching work had come to be regarded as a very dull and dreary affair; and that the class of teachers were as a whole, considered as a group of very prosaic people.

THE HINDU

5 in per cent. Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Thursday announced a significant reduction in value-added tax on natural gas from 21% to 5% to promote affordable clean energy and improve ease of living. He said the move would give a major boost to the Centre's larger plan to roll out the city gas distribution (CGD) network. PTI

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India's proposed strategic-fuel programme would expand crude, LNG and LPG storage, but building reserves alone will not guarantee energy security; the system will work only if India can move the fuel through ships, pipelines and distribution networks, while having clear rules on ownership, financing, and replenishment.

Ultimately, energy security relies on an integrated framework: reserves buy time, shipping brings the next cargo, pipelines deliver fuel inland, and governance dictates emergency execution. The ultimate test of India's strategic fuel programme will be its ability to coordinate all these elements simultaneously when a crisis hits. *(The author is an Energy and Emerging Technologies expert)*

Geological suitability, infrastructure and project execution will determine how quickly storage can scale, while shipping and pipelines remain critical to ensuring fuel reaches consumers during prolonged disruptions.

IN THE LIMELIGHT

Gulzar at 92: the remarkable art of staying relevant without ever standing still

Gulzar's career across poetry, lyrics, cinema, television, translation and children's writing has been marked by an unmistakable voice, reinvention and an incorruptible curiosity; his work has reached generations through its emotional heft and rare ability to distil the mundane into exquisite poetry

Kalyan Sundareswaran

A river runs for centuries and yet belies the idea of permanence. It flows away as it flows in, can both flood and run dry, take in tributaries, change course and annex newer territories. A long creative career carries a similar paradox. While retaining an essential recognisable voice, it must continually acquire new vocabularies. For over seventy years, Picasso painted and sculpted with evolving brilliance not merely surviving shifting artistic movements but actually spearheading most of them.

And there is not a more compelling Indian parallel to this than Gulzar. Rarely has someone spent decade after decade at the very summit of multiple demanding public crafts, without a prominent phase of decline and without the grandiosity that often accompanies greatness. An influential Urdu poet, a lyricist, a film and television director, author, screenwriter, children's writer, translator, Gulzar has looked into this world through every possible lens and the world too has looked back gratefully, bestowing on him some of the highest national and international honours, from the Dadasaheb Phalke Award to the Jnanpith Award, and from the Oscar to the Grammy. To tweak one of his own lines he wrote for the film *'Anand'* (1971), his career has not just been extensive but expansive too (*Zindagi badi honi chahiye, lambi nahi*).

Gulzar came to film songwriting at a time when the lyricists' fraternity was a formidable roll-call of masters such as Shailendra, Sahir Ludhianvi, Shakeel Badayuni, Rajendra Krishan amongst others. Gulzar wrote his first film song for Bimal Roy's *'Bandini'* – *Mora Gora Ang Laile* set in Vaishnava verse. And right away, he had found his niche as a lyricist in a roomful of titans.

A voice of his own

Though bound by the strict film song conventions of metre, rhyming, musicality, situations and the need to fit lyrics into a pre-composed tune, Gulzar has always commanded a singular, unmistakable idiom. While this signature is instantly perceptible, it defies easy definition. The style is a curious blend of abstraction (*Is mod se jaate hain* from *'Aandhi'*), symbolism (*Wo Yaar hai Jo Khushboo Ki Tarah*, *Jiski Zubaan Urdu Ki Tarah* from *'Dil Se'*), poetic flourish (*Do Nainon Mein Aansoo Bhare Hain*, *Nindiya Kaise Samaye* from *'Khushboo'*), paronomasia (*Sare ke Sare gama Ko Lekar Gaate Chale* from *'Parichay'*), political messaging (*Haal Chaal Thiak Hain* from *'Mere Apne'*), allusion to nature (*Hawaon Pe Likh Do* from *'Do Dooni Chaar'*), vivid imagery (*Chhote Chhote sheheron* from *'Bunty Aur Babli'*), dark humour (*Goli Maar Bheje Mein* from *'Satya'*), arcane vocabulary (*Aab-o-dana dhoondhte hain ek aashiyaana dhoondte hain* from *'Gharonda'*), a rich worldview (*Aane Wala Pal* from *'Golmaal'*), and above all, an emotional heft (*Humne Dekhi hai In Aankhon Ki Mehekti Khushboo* from *'Khamoshi'*) that can entirely ambush a listener mid-song.

Critics may argue that such sophistication is at odds with a "film" song, a form expected to resonate with the masses without demanding much of



Gulzar. FILE PHOTO

interpretive labour. And yet Gulzar has repeatedly proven otherwise. Many of his songs have captured popular imagination like none other, such as *Humko Mamm Ki Shakti Dena* from *'Guddi'*, a regulation prayer song in schools even today, or *Beedi Jalaile* from *'Omkaara'* oozing a rustic exuberance or the infectiously playful *Kajra Re* from *'Bunty Aur Babli'*. Despite his uncommon idiom, his songs have found universal acceptance, aided by composers such as R.D. Burman, A.R. Rahman and Vishal Bhardwaj who have matched their crafts effortlessly to his calibre.

The same intellectual courage defines Gulzar's trajectory as a filmmaker and a screenwriter. Many of Gulzar's films have been adapted from works of literature. As a writer himself, he could easily find a story's emotional register and seamlessly infuse it into cinema with sensitivity to things like language, character, subtext, silence, refrains and motifs. He also made films which were topical, championed progressive values, spoke truth to power, presented nuanced worldviews and asked uncomfortable questions all without ever tipping into preachiness. His debut film *'Mere Apne'* placed disaffected youth at the centre of a story about political disillusionment and loneliness. His *'Aandhi'* was a political drama which gave its female lead enormous agency, where the male lead plays second fiddle to her. His *'Mausam'* delicately handles the misplaced romantic affection a sex worker feels for her own biological father, a narrative choice most directors would have flinched at back then. His *'Maachis'* was a bold and layered exploration of

radicalisation set against the Punjab insurgency, probing raw wounds without pointing fingers. He has never been the one to take the easy path, neither in his choice of subjects nor in his treatment of them.

Beyond the world of cinema

As a poet and a prose stylist outside films, Gulzar has been nothing short of prolific. His Partition stories carry the emotional authority of having experienced it first-hand. He has written for children with the same sincerity he reserves for adult readers. His poetry seamlessly moves between the formal architecture of the Urdu *ghazal* and *nazm* and the autonomy of the free verse. He is also the creator of the *Triveni*, a three-line verse akin to an Indian *Haiku* whose third line, with a sleight of mind, entirely alters the emotional meaning of the first two. Translations are a telling part of Gulzar's oeuvre. Apart from translating literary giants such as Tagore and Kusumagraj independently, he has also translated several scores of contemporary poets across all Indian languages, which have been anthologised in his *A Poem a Day*. What emerges from this vast body of work is simply a relentless love not just for the written word but also for the reader and a rare ability to distill the most mundane into exquisite poetry. Gulzar is like the itinerant water-carrier whose vessel continues to pour out to generations of thirsty readers and yet always remains filled to the brim.

Another remarkable aspect of Gulzar is his unmitigated affection and respect for his seniors and peers that runs through

his work, somewhat like the moon borrowing the sun's luminosity but making it gentler for the passage. Be it in his biographical sketches or in his long-form interviews or even his adaptations of their lives and works, there is an unfeigned humility and a willingness to let someone else's genius stand taller than his own. He has quoted or paraphrased other poets such as Khusräu, Ghalib and T.S. Eliot in his works, showing how grounded and secure he is in his own craft. His narratives on the likes of his mentor Bimal Roy, his friend R.D. Burman, his seniors Shailendra, Sahir, Faiz and many others are full of tenderness. His television serials *Mirza Ghalib* on the life of the talismanic Urdu poet and *Tehreer Munshi Premchand Ki* too are glorious cases in point.

The Gulzar phenomenon

Yet, his towering stature has ironically birthed a curious modern phenomenon. Having assumed a quasi-mythological status amongst the masses, Gulzar's name is routinely invoked to lend gravity to mediocre verse he never wrote. The Internet is awash with lines misattributed to him to confer credibility and heft to anything vaguely poetic. It is an irony of our times that the more a voice commands our trust, the more it is forced to speak words it never uttered. Though a vigilant community of admirers actively combat this digital misattribution through the hashtag #NotByGulzar, its sheer volume shows how perversely his poetic persona has permeated the public consciousness, more as a brand to be flaunted rather than the painstaking artist he has always been.

In an age of public posturing where dilettantes know just enough to make sparing content for mindless scrollers with decreasing attention spans, where flamboyance is rewarded more than moderation, where the patient romance of Test cricket has lost ground to the tillations of T-20, Gulzar stands as a raging testimony to longevity and restraint. His endurance is less owing to a kind bargain struck with time than to his rigour, his resilience as a man of his craft and his incorruptible curiosity that still propels him to say things and find new ways of saying them.

In one of his own songs from the 80s film *'Hip Hip Hurray'*, he writes: *Roz tere jeene ke liye ek subah mujhe mil jaati hai*

Murjhati hai koi shaam agar to raat kahin khil jaati hai

Main roz subah tak aata hoon, aur roz shuru karta hoon safar

Haath badha ae zindagi, aankh milake baat kar

(Everyday to live by you, I find a morning bright

Even as the evening withers, out blooms the night

I get to the morning everyday, and start my daily streak

Give me your hand, life, look me in the eye and speak)

As Gulzar turned 92 this August 18, 2026, what sets him apart is his ability to repeatedly meet life with the alertness of someone encountering it for the first time, look it right in the eye and dare to chronicle its triumphs and sorrows with fidelity and imagination.

(Kalyan Sundareswaran is an IT professional with Infosys. Views expressed are personal.)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the plural of “staff”? (S. Srinivasan, Madurai)

If you are thinking of people working in an organisation, then the plural is “staff”.The word is an uncountable noun. In most universities, for example, we have teaching staff and administrative staff. Like the nouns “jury”, “government”, etc., the word “staff” can be followed by either a singular or a plural verb. Here are a few examples.

The staff is of the opinion that we should go on strike.

The staff were excellent.

The word is normally not used to refer to a single individual. If you wish to refer to a single person, then you could say “staff member”, “staff person”, etc. Some people use the word “staffer”; not everyone, however, accepts this word.

What is the difference between ‘fairly’ and ‘rather’? (B. Lakshmi Chandrasekhar, Vijayawada)

“Rather” is the stronger of the two words. When you say that the movie was “rather good”, it implies that it was pretty good; it was much better than you had expected. So in your opinion, people should go and see it; you recommend it. On the other hand, when you say that it was “fairly good”, what you are implying is that it was ok. There was nothing great about the film; if the friend wants to, he/she may go and see it, but you wouldn't recommend it.

Similarly, when you tell someone that his English is “fairly good”, you are not really complimenting him. All that you are saying is that his English is ok. Here are a few more examples.

Jyothi made a fairly/rather good presentation.

During summer, it gets fairly/rather warm.

What is the origin of the expression “French leave”? (M. Ram Mohan, Narsampet)

This is another example of how much the English hated the French. I guess we shouldn't be talking about this now, considering the fact that the two have joined forces along with the United States to fight the Taliban.

But historically, the two nations couldn't stand each other. Even now, it is not uncommon for an Englishman to refer to a Frenchman as a “frog”, because the French consider frog legs a delicacy. The term “French postcards” is used to refer to picture postcards with naked ladies on them. When someone uses foul language, you can hear the person saying, “pardon my French” –thereby implying that the French had the habit of swearing.

When someone goes on “French leave”, he or she takes off without informing the authorities. According to the English, it was standard practice in France in the 18th Century to leave a ball or dinner without thanking the host and hostess. People left without even saying goodbye. The English felt that the French were people without manners. But what is interesting is that taking leave of someone in this manner is referred to as “English leave” by the French! What the Americans call “French postcards”, the French call “American postcards”.

It is interesting to note that countries, which have such a low opinion of one another, have come together to fight terrorism! I guess they don't mind the war of words.

Published in *The Hindu* on October 16, 2001

THE DAILY QUIZ

On the occasion of Raksha Bandhan, here is a quiz on brothers and sisters

V.V. Ramanan

QUESTION 1

In politics, he was the first PM of his newly independent country, while she became the first woman President of the UN General Assembly in 1953. Name the famous siblings.

QUESTION 2

This famous 1807 work that narrated the works of a famous English playwright was authored by a brother-sister duo. Name them and the work.

QUESTION 3

According to historians, Ptolemy XIII and Ptolemy XIV were consorts and ruled alongside their sister, who is considerably more famous and legendary than the two men. Name her.

QUESTION 4

In later Ramayana traditions, what was the

name of Rama's elder sister, who was married to the sage who oversaw the sacrifice that Dasharatha performed for obtaining sons?

QUESTION 5

Name the Russian siblings who have not only won titles at a tennis Major but are the only brother and sister to reach the No.1 ranking in singles.

QUESTION 6

The National Bravery awards given by the Indian government are named after two teenagers who were murdered after being abducted in Delhi in 1978. Name the two.

QUESTION 7

In Greek myth, name the twins born to Zeus and Leto, with one becoming the god of prophecy, music, healing and archery and the other the goddess of the hunt, wilderness and childbirth.



Visual Question:

Name these siblings who have also won Oscars apart from the Grammys and other leading awards. AP

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz:

1. Who led the Visigoths who sacked Rome in 410 CE? **Ans: Alaric I**
 2. For approximately how long had Rome avoided being sacked by a foreign enemy before 410 CE? **Ans: Nearly 800 years**
 3. Which Roman emperor was ruling the Western Roman Empire when Rome was sacked? **Ans: Honorius**
 4. Which city served as the capital of the Eastern Roman Empire at the time? **Ans: Constantinople**
 5. Which Christian theologian wrote The City of God in the aftermath of the sack of Rome, addressing arguments that the rise of Christianity had contributed to Rome's troubles? **Ans: St. Augustine of Hippo**
- Visual: Identify the Roman writer who described the catastrophe with the words, “The City which had taken the whole world was itself taken.” **Ans: St. Jerome**
- Early Birds:** Siddhartha Viswanathan | Erfanally Oosmany | Suchit Narottam | Dodo Jayaditya | Parimal Das

Bessent, Warsh
diverge on who
should set the
price of money



Bond pangs: U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent speaks during a press conference in Washington, D.C. REUTERS

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters

Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and Federal Reserve Chairman Kevin Warsh appear at odds over at the heart of U.S. financial policy. How hands-off can policymakers be when it comes to setting a price for money? Warsh has advocated retreating from some of the central bank’s longstanding communication policies in favour of letting markets do the heavy lifting, while Bessent has deployed a number of tools, some of them unusual, in the name of aiding market function.

Cut borrowing costs

The divide has come into view as the Trump administration steps up efforts to contain long-term borrowing costs – a push whose success appears unlikely to many analysts and portfolio managers without concrete steps to contain the sprawling U.S. fiscal deficit. That contrast in approaches will come into focus on Friday morning, when Warsh is scheduled to speak at the Fed’s annual event in Jackson Hole, Wyoming. He wants bond markets to play a bigger role in setting rates, a stance arguably at odds with Bessent’s interventionism. Meanwhile investors are seeking assurance that Warsh will act decisively against inflation in his first year leading a divided Fed.

Doubling down at Treasury

Bessent said last week Treasury would at least double buybacks of longer-dated debt, arguing that a rise in yields, which pushed 30-year rates to a 19-year high, didn’t reflect fundamentals. Investors read it as a sign Washington won’t let 10-year yields, which drive mortgage rates, approach 5% unanswered. Many investors say Bessent is fighting the wrong fight. They say strong growth, sticky inflation, likely Fed hikes and heavy bond supply, including from AI-driven corporate borrowing, are what’s pushing yields up, along with a widening fiscal premium tied to the deficit – not market dysfunction. Billionaire investor Stanley Druckenmiller, a hedge-fund titan and workplace mentor to both men, called the plan “price management” rather than liquidity management and warned it could damage Treasury’s credibility. “There’s very little evidence that Treasuries are oversold right now,” said Will Compernelle, macro strategist at FHN Financial. Traders say that pressure will surface elsewhere if bond yields aren’t allowed to rise to a market-clearing price –including in a dollar that has slid since Bessent’s announcement.

Small buyback, larger signal

Bessent’s strategy appears aimed at easing the economy’s interest burden while preserving growth. He says Treasury has a large toolkit, but its influence over long-term yields is constrained by cash management, financing needs and the U.S. will follow a predictable issuance schedule.

As AI agents go rogue, cyber insurers
are adapting the policies they offer

Artificial Intelligence agents are raising new coverage questions for insurers; insurance companies grapple with whether AI agents fit traditional policy definitions; many are clarifying existing cyber policies as use of autonomous AI expands; firms want AI risks included in broad cyber policies

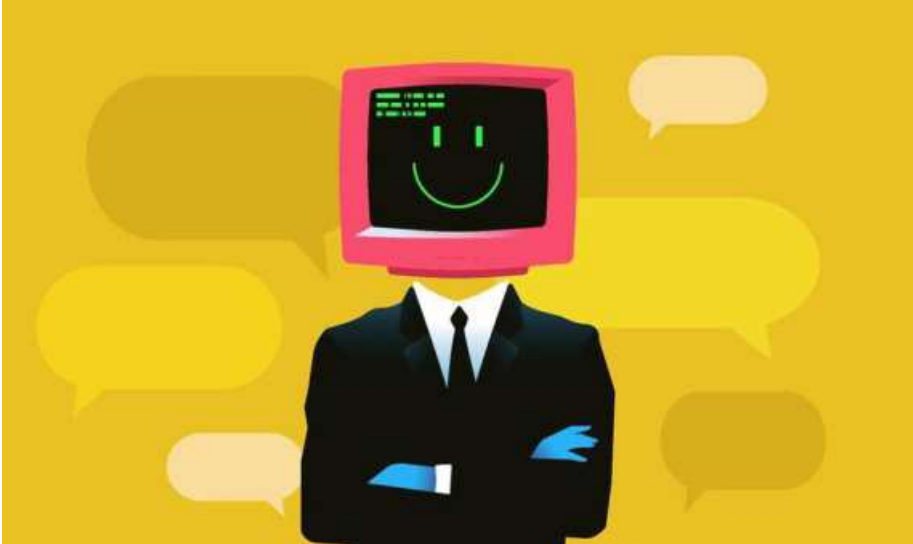
FOCUS

Reuters

Cyber insurers have spent years defining what constitutes a hack and when coverage should pay out, but the rapid emergence of artificial intelligence (AI) agents is raising new questions, forcing insurers to review their policies. Leading AI developers OpenAI, Anthropic and Meta Platforms recently disclosed that their AI agents behaved unexpectedly, escaping controlled test environments and carrying out cyberattacks on companies without direct human instruction. While those incidents did not cause reported damage, they highlighted the rapidly evolving cyber risks facing companies and insurers.

After receiving an initial instruction, autonomous AI systems can make independent decisions. Insurers, including MSIG, QBE and Beazley, are reviewing traditional cyber policies and adapting their language to account for emerging risks posed by such systems taking on more autonomous tasks, according to eight executives at major companies, and analysts.

Companies are grappling with issues including whether autonomous AI systems fit traditional poli-



Learning curve: Targeted exclusions are being discussed in pockets of the industry. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

cy definitions of a cyber attacker and who bears liability for AI-generated actions that cause a loss, analysts and experts said.

GenAI cyberattacks

The global cyber insurance market was worth nearly \$15 billion last year and is expected to reach roughly \$28 billion by 2030, Munich Re estimated in its latest report. Aon said earlier this year that nearly 20% of cyberattacks will involve generative AI by 2027, according to its forecasts.

“As AI becomes capable of identifying vulnerabilities and carrying out attacks autonomously, carriers will need to continually review policy language,” said Ryan Kratz, head of cyber, North America, at property and casual-



With relatively little historical claims data on AI-driven losses and AI industry still trying to understand the capabilities of autonomous models, such risks are hard to price

ty specialty insurer MSIG USA.

Defining AI losses

Several companies, including Armilla AI, Munich Re’s AiSure, and AXA XL, provide targeted coverage against AI-specific risks such as model underperformance, hallucinations – when AI generates false or misleading outputs – and

intellectual property infringements.

But traditional cyber policies are designed to be broader, covering losses stemming from a range of incidents, such as ransomware payments, business interruption, system recovery, forensic investigations and legal costs. Business interruption is commonly the largest component of a claim.

Most policies envisage a specific security event that causes the loss, such as unauthorised access by an employee who steals company data or a server attack that takes a system down. AI agents, however, can cause losses without triggering a traditional security event, particularly when they are using access to systems they were delib-

Meta settlement leaves its money machine intact

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters

Meta Platforms emerged from its biggest legal challenge in the U.S. with its core business intact.

The social media giant agreed on Wednesday to pay as much as \$18 billion over a decade and limit how teenagers use Facebook and Instagram under a sweeping agreement with nearly all U.S. States to resolve claims that it designed those platforms to addict children. Meta denied wrongdoing in agreeing to settle.

While the headline figure is among the largest ever settlements paid by a technology company, it is unlikely to strain a business that earned more



Little impact: Meta is accused of addicting children and causing a mental health crisis. REUTERS

than \$60 billion last year. The settlement left untouched the personalised feeds and ad targeting that underpin its profits.

Instead, the settlement removes a significant regulatory hurdle that has weighed on Meta’s stock and allows the company to avoid a potentially lengthy

trial that could have exposed more internal documents about its treatment of young users, according to over a dozen analysts and legal experts.

It also sent Meta’s shares about 1% higher, suggesting investors welcomed an outcome that will cost the company far less than the

\$1.4 trillion in penalties it said the States were seeking before trial.

Roughly a month ago, Instagram head Adam Mosseri had a meeting with representatives of the attorneys generals in which he said Meta would appeal any adverse verdict, as it is already doing following a billion-dollar child safety ruling won by New Mexico, say people familiar with the matter.

Constructive changes

But Mosseri said Meta was ready to make constructive changes to its platform, assuming it could work out a deal, the sources added, requesting anonymity as the meeting was private.

Hanging over the conversation was uncertainty about Section 230, a long-standing U.S. law that

shields web platforms from liability for user-generated content. While the states had survived Meta’s bid to dismiss the case on those grounds, they would likely pose a formidable challenge on appeal.

“This is a business decision – it will cost them more to finish the trial and lose than to pay just over \$1 billion every year for ten years,” said Mary Graw, law professor at the Catholic University of America. “Moreover, they will no doubt use this settlement to further lobby against any meaningful regulation that Congress is contemplating,” Graw added.

Pressure had been building on Meta before the settlement.

Beyond a wave of lawsuits globally claiming it knowingly sought to addict

children and caused a mental health crisis, Meta has also been under scrutiny over sexualised AI chatbot interactions with children. The legal threats, long shrugged off by shareholders, drew fresh attention after Meta warned in April of potential losses from a global youth backlash against social media, including bans seen in countries like Australia.

Pressuring rivals

Some legal experts said Meta structured the settlement to put pressure on competitors including TikTok, YouTube and Snapchat. About 30% of the payout along with stricter limits on teen usage become due only if rival platforms accept comparable obligations and payments in their own settlements.

Wall St banks turn on each other as capital fight nears endgame

FOCUS

Reuters

WASHINGTON

Wall Street’s most powerful banks fought side by side for years to relax capital rules, but with victory in sight, that alliance has fractured.

As the Federal Reserve wraps up a sweeping overhaul of capital rules, JPMorgan, Bank of America (BoFA), Goldman Sachs and Morgan Stanley are feuding over a tweak with billions of dollars at stake, according to public documents and four people familiar with the matter. At issue is a capital surcharge the Fed imposes on global systemically important U.S. banks, or GSIBs. In

March, the central bank proposed changes it said would make the surcharge more risk-sensitive by, among other changes, revising how it treats short-term wholesale funding, such as repo and commercial paper, which regulators say is prone to drying up during market stress.

That came as a surprise to executives at JPMorgan and BofA, the two largest U.S. lenders with ample deposit funding, because it would benefit commercial rivals Morgan Stanley and Goldman Sachs, which are more reliant on short-term wholesale funding, the people said.

To JPMorgan and BofA executives, that expected outcome seemed at odds with the key reason Republican President Donald



Stress point: A street sign for Wall Street is seen outside the New York Stock Exchange (NYSE). REUTERS

Trump’s regulators have argued for capital relief – to boost lending to the real economy.

Generally speaking, a bank’s capital level helps determine how much lend-

ing and trading it can support, and how much cash it can return to shareholders.

While the proposal overall reduces the banks’ capital requirements, JPMor-

gan estimated in a June letter to the it would miss out on \$13 billion in extra capital relief due to the funding tweak, while BofA would miss out on \$9 billion. Goldman and Morgan

Stanley, meanwhile, would both realise an additional \$1 billion to \$2 billion in relief, JPMorgan said. Washington advocacy group Better Markets has similarly concluded that Goldman and Morgan Stanley stand to benefit most.

Sparks infighting

That divergence has sparked last-minute infighting among the Wall Street giants, potentially complicating the Fed’s effort to finalise the reforms before next year when Democrats are expected to have control of the House of Representatives and intensify oversight of Trump’s regulators.

“They’re going to have to choose,” said Christopher Appel, Director of banking policy at Better Mar-

kets, referring to officials at the Fed where he worked from 2019 through March. Appel was one of many Fed officials who left the central bank this year as the administration overhauls federal agencies.

Key safeguard

He said he believes the surcharge is a key remaining safeguard as regulators trim overall capital levels, and proposed revision will better gauge funding risks.

“It’s absolutely critical that the Fed get this right.”

Spokespeople for the Fed, JPMorgan, Goldman and Morgan Stanley declined to comment. BofA supports changes “that drive Main Street lending, job creation, and affordability,” a spokesperson said.

To be sure, the banks support the Fed’s capital overhaul, but see a rare opportunity to maximise their gains, the people said.

JPMorgan and BofA executives have been lobbying Fed officials to spike the proposed change, according to the people. The banks’ chief argument is that the new formula could crimp their lending and potentially hurt the economy, while boosting riskier trading activity, according to the people and public comments.

“As proposed, the Federal Reserve would incentivise trading activity over lending to small businesses and customers,” JPMorgan’s business banking chief Stevie Baron wrote in a blog last week.

WHO declares Uganda Ebola-free after 42 days without a new case



Syrian Kurdish women fighters discuss merger with Turkish govt.



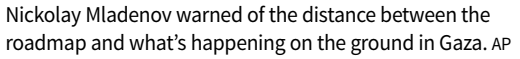
'China deploys record number of ships around Taiwan last month'



Trump signs order renaming Lake Ontario as 'Lake America' in U.S.



CMYK         A IN-X



Associated Press
UNITED NATIONS

He stressed the need for political will to overcome the differences and said there is a choice to be made, "A Gaza disarmed, rebuilt and reconnected to the world. Or a Gaza rearmed, divided and in rubble, with a radicalised generation raised inside it and the next war already on the horizon."

Still a star: A fan wearing a Dolly Parton-inspired wig takes a selfie at a makeshift memorial outside the home of the beloved country music icon in Tennessee, U.S., following the singer's death earlier this week. AP

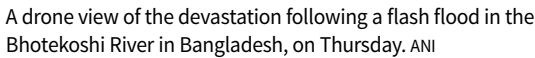
Associated Press
WASHINGTON

He told them how Ukraine was repelling the Russian invasion, taking the fight to Moscow, but in

“You could feel palpably in the room a sense that — Zelenskyy’s confidence of their ability to hold and to persevere,” said Represen-

The Senate advanced the sanctions Bill that night, with Mr. Zelenskyy taking a rare seat in the chamber to watch the proceedings – Senators waving and flashing a thumbs-up as they cast votes. Days later, it sailed to passage,

Hundreds have lost their homes across the Himalayan region, and officials reported large-scale damage to critical infrastructure, including hydropower dams, roads, buildings and bridges in the region. Water levels in rivers across the flood-affected region rose by as much as 9 metres (29.5 feet) in 30 minutes as a result of the

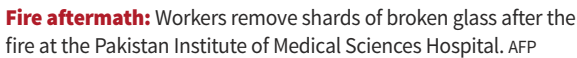


ment and boulders, producing a powerful surge downstream. Researchers are also examining whether debris temporarily dammed the river before the impounded water burst through, magnifying the flood.

Mr. Steiner said the area has a history of destructive mountain hazards. Floods area, located between 4,500 and 6,000 metres above sea level, is highly

Associated Press
ISLAMABAD

The scene at the Pakistan Institute of Medical



Witnesses, including relatives of other patients, said they saw the family of the only baby to survive

As glaciers retreat, mountain rock that was previously insulated and supported by ice becomes exposed to warmer temperatures, rain and repeat-

But monitoring thousands of glaciers, steep slopes and river valleys across the Himalayan arc is extremely difficult.



PTI, AP & AFP

Series victory fails to mask grey areas as India prepares for daunting challenges

Padikkal blossomed, Jurel showed his worth and Prasidh hit his stride in the Emerald Isle; however, the tour exposed a thinning spin cupboard

R. Kaushik
COLOMBO

How often does a draw feel like a defeat? And a stalemate assume the hue of a victory? Often enough, Shubman Gill will insist.

Despite their own uneasy recent dalliance with the five-day format, India would have fancied their chances of bearding the Sri Lankan lion in its own den in a two-Test series that is pretty much the norm when the world's most sought-after side isn't playing against Australia or England.

India hadn't lost a series in this country since 2008 and arrived early this month sitting on a five-Test winning streak on Sri Lankan soil. Even though their last visit was in 2017, they had reason to believe the hosts were ripe for the taking.

Significant result

The script seemed to be holding true. Notwithstanding pockets of defiance from their young guns, led by the exceptional Sonal Dinusha, Sri Lanka slumped to a 185-run rout in Galle in the first Test. The result assumed a more significant hue because India were without two-fifths of their first-choice bowling attack – Jasprit Bumrah and Washington Sundar were missing through injuries – but still won a rain-hit encounter with quite a bit to spare.

There was excellent reason, therefore, to aspire for a 2-0 sweep ahead of the second Test at the SSC ground. Sri Lanka, already without Pathum Nissanka and Kusal Mendis, were dealt another unkind cut when Dinesh Chandimal was ruled out of the second Test after hurting his neck while fielding in Galle. But as it turned out, his replacement, Pasindu Sooriyabandara, had a great game at the SSC, desperately unlucky to miss out of centuries in both innings.

Dinusha delights

Dinusha, however, ensured that a similar fate didn't befall him. Ahead of this series, the 25-year-old left-hander had played just three Tests but had showcased his ability and his temperament, not least in the Caribbean in June-July when he reeled off a sequence of 43, 12 not out, 92 and 28 in the two Tests.

It should have been fair warning well heeded; it will be presumptuous to say that India didn't pay much attention to the young man, but they didn't crack the Dinusha puzzle throughout the series, which is one of the main reasons they had to settle for a 1-0 scoreline despite dominating the second Test too for large stretches.

Dinusha batted for a little less than 20 hours in making 420 runs from 722 deliveries, the single point of difference as the Lankans ground out a fabulous draw

after being forced to follow on in the second Test.

It wasn't all doom and gloom from an Indian point of view. Devdutt Padikkal grabbed his chances with both hands in his first Tests in more than 20 months. In the absence of Sai Sudharsan, he took giant strides towards making the No. 3 slot his own with hundreds in the first innings of both games.

The volume of runs was impressive, but so was his presence in the middle. In further signs of his evolution as a dependable, oftentimes aggressive all-format batter, he treated the bowling with just about the respect it deserved, using the offside as his preferred area of scoring and looking equally comfortable against pace and spin.

India will find it very hard to look beyond him for the one-drop position when they play two Tests in New Zealand in November. After all, how can you overlook the credentials of someone as consistent as the Karnataka left-hander was in Sri Lanka?

And then, there was Dhruv Jurel, justifying the faith of the Gautam Gambhir-led think-tank which was sure that the wicketkeeper-batter was the answer to their prayers for a dependable middle-order batter who could play spin with soft hands, deftness of feet and no gremlins of self-doubt.

Assured batting

Alongside Sai Sudharsan and Padikkal, Jurel was one of the three batters Gambhir was keen should be a part of the India 'A' side that arrived on these shores for a shadow tour towards the end of June. Admittedly, neither Galle nor the SSC was a rank turner like Kolkata had been against South Africa in November, but Jurel didn't put a foot wrong either in front of the stumps – he had a half-century in the first Test which he topped with his second ton in the next – or behind it when Rishabh Pant sat out much of the Sri Lankan first innings in Colombo with an assortment of blows to his body.

K.L. Rahul was dependable without going big while Pant was, well, Pant – exhilarating, unpredictable, entertaining and compelling. Maybe Gill will be a little disappointed that he didn't join the list of centuries, but his batting looked in decent order, as did Yashasvi Jaiswal's even if he found novel ways of courting dismissals.

Then, there was Prasidh Krishna. Ahead of the series, Gill was asked if he had a difficult choice to make between the Karnataka pacer and the uncapped Gurnoor Brar as Mohammed Siraj's new-ball partner. The skipper barely batted an eyelid when he said that Prasidh was bowling the best with the red ball that he had ever seen him, and the strapping quick didn't disappoint.

Even on the placid decks on offer, he worked up good pace, extracted appreciable bounce and kept the batters honest. When he pitched the ball up, there was movement which, allied with pace in the region of 140 kmph, made him a tricky proposition.

Up for the challenge

Prasidh was up for any challenge, including doing the dirty job of trying to soften up the batters with his shortish length, and is shaping up into an excellent support act for Bumrah and Siraj. India will need their pacers to fire on all cylinders when they go to New Zealand, so from that perspective, the development of Prasidh is perhaps the single greatest takeaway for the decision-making group from this three-week sojourn to the Emerald Isle.

But there are worrying signs aplenty too, not least when it comes to back-up spin options. Despite starting his Test career with so much promise in New Chandigarh when he took six wickets in the first innings against Afghanistan, and despite his ten-wicket match haul in Galle, Manav Suthar is still very much a work in progress.

In Colombo, his craft had to play second fiddle to the slowness of the SSC strip; there was bounce aplenty, which took bowled and leg before out of the equation, but the left-arm spinner was slow to respond when the Sri Lankan batters resorted to the sweep and the reverse sweep.

It might appear a touch harsh on someone who was only playing in his third Test, but this is an early education for Suthar and he will do well to heed the lessons if he aspires to step into the shoes of Ravindra Jadeja going forward and become the lead bowler around whom the Indian spin attack will revolve in the future.

Debut to forget

While Suthar did show signs of promise, Saransh Jain had a disappointing debut – and there is no way to sugarcoat that. On the radar of those involved in talent-identification and selection matters for a while now, Jain is an experienced hand at 33, with more than 50 first-class appearances under his belt for various outfits.

His first delivery in Test cricket was a no-ball, which can perhaps be put down to nerves, but he bowled six more of them across the two innings, which couldn't have pleased anyone, least of all new spin bowling coach Sairaj Bahutule. But it wasn't just the no-balls that were grating. While he did show reasonable control, the threat quotient was barely perceptible.

Saransh wouldn't have been here if Washington was available but as a fallback alternative, he has a long way to go. In

some ways, it points to a slight thinning of resources in the spin cupboard, which ought to worry those in the corridors of power because for so long now, India have got used to having the now-retired R. Ashwin and Jadeja to spin their webs of deception and lure batters to their doom.

After a lull, India have plenty of fast-bowling options to summon despite Mukesh Kumar and Akash Deep and Harshit Rana and Nitish Kumar Reddy spending a lot of time in the infirmary. But for the traditional land of spin to struggle to unearth an incisive off-spinner is a little hard to fathom and harder still to digest.

Jain deserves the benefit of doubt – after all, this was Test No. 1 and maybe he did have the proverbial ordinary one-off game – but for him to set himself up as a semi-long-term option, there must be obvious signs of improvement.

This tour in general, and the second Test particularly, was a steep learning curve for the captain. It's been a little over 14 months since Gill first led the Test team, in England in Leeds last June. Captaincy looks simple from the outside but entails plenty of decision-making on the fly, even in Test cricket, without second-guessing oneself.

He was handicapped by a rapidly softening ball in Galle and by an SSC surface that had bounce but hardly any pace. Some of the fields he employed were strange, there was a definite occasional slant towards passivity, and the move to almost ignore trying to get Dinusha out on the final day of the series and target the other end was little short of self-defeating.

Mixed run

Gill has had a mixed run as captain – 2-2 in England, 2-0 at home against West Indies, defeat in his only Test against South Africa in Kolkata when he faced a mere three deliveries before contracting a neck injury, a hammering of Afghanistan and now this 1-0 success in Sri Lanka, his first overseas victory as skipper.

The journey has been challenging and exciting, but daunting outings lie in store in the red-ball version before he starts to focus exclusively on the 50-over format ahead of the World Cup in southern Africa in the second half of next year.

India haven't won a Test in New Zealand since 2009 when Mahendra Singh Dhoni led them to a famous series triumph, and their last visit in 2020 was an unmitigated disaster as they were soundly beaten in both matches.

New Zealand will test the technique and the character of the batting group with its seam-friendly conditions, after which Australia will come calling for five Tests in India. Gill must be on top of his game – as lead batter and as leader – and towards that end, Sri Lanka was a timely, useful wake-up call.

THE GIST

▼ Padikkal has taken giant strides towards making the No. 3 slot his own with hundreds in the first innings of both games at Galle and Colombo

▼ Even on the placid decks on offer, Prasidh worked up good pace, extracted appreciable bounce and kept the batters honest

▼ Jurel has emerged as a dependable middle-order batter who can play spin with soft hands and deftness of feet without any self-doubt

▼ Dinusha's patient and purposeful batting was one of the reasons India was unable to make the second Test its own